

Familiar impasse: On the global response to eliminating plastic pollution

Talks on **limiting** use of plastic **must** be **built on mutual trust**

Global **resistance** to a universal **treaty** on eliminating plastic pollution **remains stubborn** and huge. Last week, the sixth **attempt** since 2022 by the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) to get member-nations to agree upon a treaty to **address** plastic pollution **ran** into the familiar **vortex** of opposition. There was **disagreement** among the major **blocs** of countries on whether **comprehensively** addressing plastic pollution requires eliminating plastic production itself. All countries agree that the **ubiquitous polythene bag**, despite its **immense practicability** and **affordability** as a container, **has ballooned** into a civic crisis. India generates around 3.4 million tonnes (MT) of plastic waste but recycles only about 30%. Its plastic consumption rose at a **compounded annual growth rate** (CAGR) of 9.7% from 14 MT in 2016-17 to over 20 MT in 2019-20. India has a production ban on about 20 single-use plastic items — cups, straws, spoons. While this has, **to some extent, induced** a degree of behavioural change — in greater **reliance** of paper and cloth bags — it has had little impact on waste management and recycling. This is also **reflective** of the global picture. According to the UNEP, the world produces more than 430 MT of plastic annually, two-thirds of which are **short-lived** products that soon become waste. Overall, 46% of plastic waste is landfilled, while 22% is **mismanaged** and becomes **litter**. In 2019, **plastic**, which is a **derivate** of **fossilised crude**, **generated** 1.8 billion metric tonnes of **greenhouse gas emissions** or about 3.4% of the global total.

Plastic, therefore, **can** be seen as a waste management problem that can be solved by improving **incentives** for the market to do a better job of collecting waste and recycling. However, there are countries that **point to** the **decades** of attempts made on these lines, with **limited** gains. To add to that, more evidence has **piled up** that plastic, **non-biodegradable** as it is, is making its way into human, animal and **marine** food systems. Island-nations and territories are **swamped** by plastic waste **washing up on their shores**. Then there are **granular** forms of plastic — or microplastics — with **potential** for harm. Thus, the only real solution is to reduce at source. However, nations are not all agreed upon this **aspect** of **toxicity**. Therefore, in treaty-linked talks, they view calls to cut production as **tactics** to impose trade barriers and **add to** the general climate of tariff **uncertainty**. Unless countries can build greater trust before such talks and hear each other out with an open mind, having more meetings will only be **futile**. **The halcyon days**, when some countries could **steer resolutions** on the environment assuming that the '**common good**' was **incontrovertible**, **are long past**.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

[Practice Exercise]

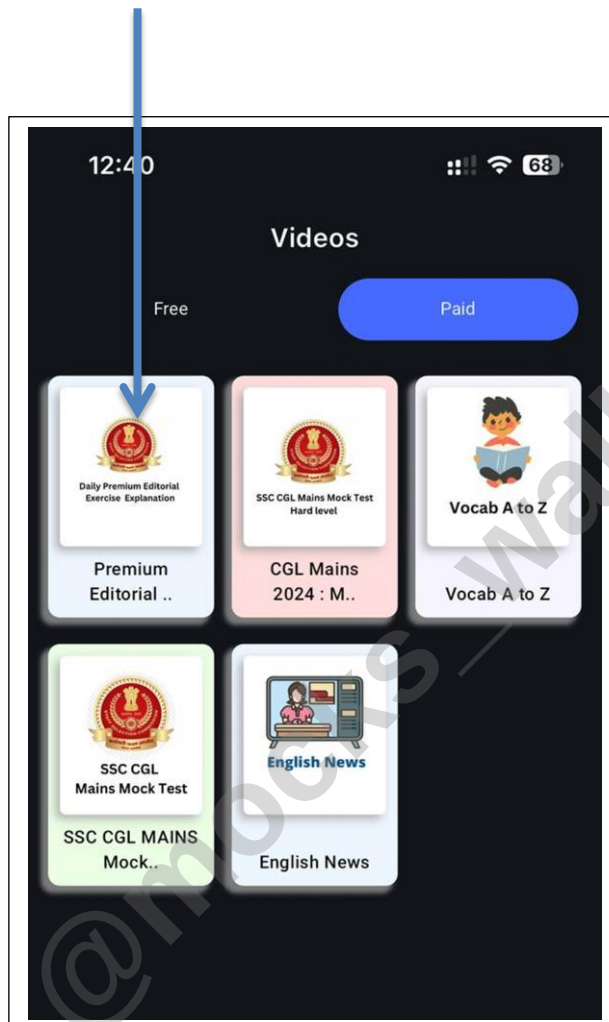
Vocabulary

1. **Impasse** (noun) – deadlock, stalemate, gridlock, standstill, logjam गतिरोध
2. **Eliminate** (verb) – remove, eradicate, abolish, phase out, wipe out समाप्त करना
3. **Limiting** (adjective) – restrictive, constraining, bounding, capping, narrowing सीमितकारी
4. **Build (on)** (verb) – capitalize on, leverage, draw upon, expand on, develop further आधार पर विकसित करना
5. **Mutual** (adjective) – reciprocal, shared, common, joint, two-way परस्पर
6. **Resistance** (noun) – opposition, pushback, defiance, reluctance, obstruction प्रतिरोध
7. **Treaty** (noun) – agreement, pact, accord, convention, compact संधि
8. **Stubborn** (adjective) – obstinate, intransigent, unyielding, adamant, rigid हठी
9. **Address** (verb) – tackle, deal with, confront, resolve, attend to समाधान करना
10. **Vortex** (noun) – whirlpool, maelstrom, swirl, eddy, whirlwind भँवर
11. **Disagreement** (noun) – dispute, dissent, discord, conflict, divergence असहमति
12. **Bloc** (noun) – coalition, alliance, group, caucus, grouping गुट
13. **Comprehensively** (adverb) – thoroughly, holistically, exhaustively, across-the-board, in full व्यापक रूप से
14. **Ubiquitous** (adjective) – omnipresent, pervasive, widespread, all-pervading, ever-present सर्वव्यापी
15. **Immense** (adjective) – huge, enormous, vast, tremendous, colossal विशाल
16. **Practicability** (noun) – feasibility, workability, viability, doability, practicality व्यवहार्यता
17. **Affordability** (noun) – low cost, economy, budget-friendliness, cost efficiency, price accessibility वहनीयता
18. **Balloon** (verb) – surge, swell, skyrocket, escalate, mushroom तेज़ी से बढ़ना
19. **Compounded annual growth rate (CAGR)** (noun) – the average yearly growth rate of an investment over a time period greater than one year. चक्रवृद्धि वार्षिक वृद्धि दर
20. **At some extent** (phrase) – partly, somewhat, in part, to a degree, moderately कुछ हद तक
21. **Induce** (verb) – cause, prompt, spur, bring about, engender प्रेरित करना
22. **Reliance** (noun) – dependence, trust, leaning, dependence on, reliance upon निर्भरता

23. **Reflective** (adjective) – indicative, emblematic, symptomatic, illustrative, representative संकेतात्मक
24. **Short-lived** (adjective) – fleeting, transient, ephemeral, temporary, passing अल्पकालिक
25. **Mismanage** (verb) – mishandle, botch, misdirect, misgovern, bungle कुप्रबंधन करना
26. **Litter** (noun) – trash, rubbish, waste, debris, garbage कूड़ा
27. **Derivate** (noun) – derivative, by-product, offshoot, spin-off, outgrowth उप-उत्पाद
28. **Fossilised crude** (noun) – crude oil, a fossil fuel, that has formed from the remains of ancient plants and animals over millions of years कच्चा तेल
29. **Greenhouse gas emission** (noun) – the release of gases into the atmosphere that trap heat and contribute to the greenhouse effect, which warms the planet ग्रीनहाउस गैस
30. **Emission** (noun) – discharge, release, output, effluent, outflow उत्सर्जन
31. **Incentive** (noun) – motivation, inducement, stimulus, spur, reward प्रोत्साहन
32. **Point to** (phrasal verb) – indicate, highlight, draw attention to, signal, suggest संकेत करना
33. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years दशक
34. **Limited** (adjective) – restricted, narrow, modest, constrained, finite सीमित
35. **Pile up** (phrasal verb) – accumulate, amass, mount, build up, stack up इकट्ठा होना
36. **Non-biodegradable** (adjective) – non-decomposable, persistent, non-compostable, durable, non-biodegrading अविघटनीय
37. **Marine** (adjective) – oceanic, sea, maritime, nautical, pelagic समुद्री
38. **Swamp** (verb) – overwhelm, inundate, flood, deluge, overrun भर देना
39. **Wash up on one's shores** (phrase) – wash ashore, be carried onto beaches, be washed up, land on coasts, be cast ashore तट पर बहकर आना
40. **Granular** (adjective) – detailed, fine-grained, particulate, grainy, micro-level सूक्ष्म-दानेदार
41. **Potential** (noun) – capacity, possibility, capability, promise, latent power संभाव्यता
42. **Aspect** (noun) – facet, dimension, angle, element, feature पक्ष

43. **Toxicity** (noun) – poisonousness, harmfulness, toxicity level, virulence, noxiousness विषाक्तता
44. **Tactic** (noun) – strategy, ploy, maneuver, gambit, move चाल
45. **Add to** (phrasal verb) – increase, exacerbate, heighten, compound, augment बढ़ाना
46. **Uncertainty** (noun) – unpredictability, instability, doubt, ambiguity, volatility अनिश्चितता
47. **Futile** (adjective) – pointless, useless, vain, fruitless, ineffective निष्फल
48. **The halcyon days** (phrase) – golden days, salad days, glory days, golden age, heyday सुनहरे दिन
49. **Steer** (verb) – guide, direct, pilot, shepherd, navigate दिशा देना
50. **Resolution** (noun) – decision, motion, measure, declaration, determination प्रस्ताव
51. **Common good** (phrase) – public interest, collective welfare, greater good, social benefit, public good सार्वजनिक हित
52. **Incontrovertible** (adjective) – indisputable, unquestionable, irrefutable, certain, undeniable निर्विवाद
53. **Be long past** (phrase) – be over, be behind us, be bygone, be well past, belong to the past बहुत पीछे छूट जाना

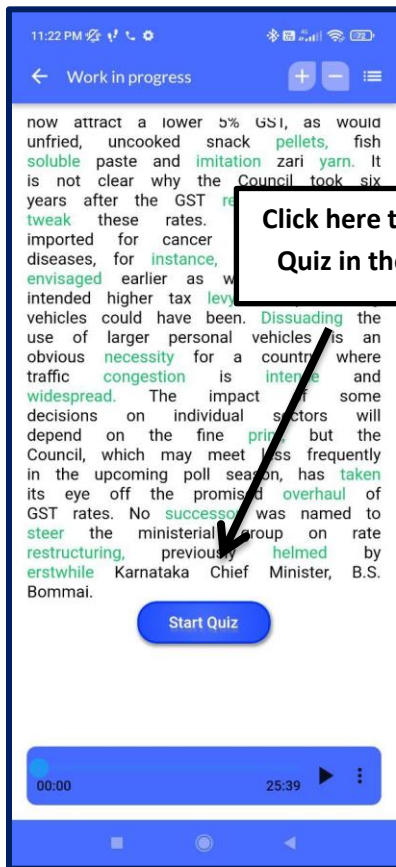
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



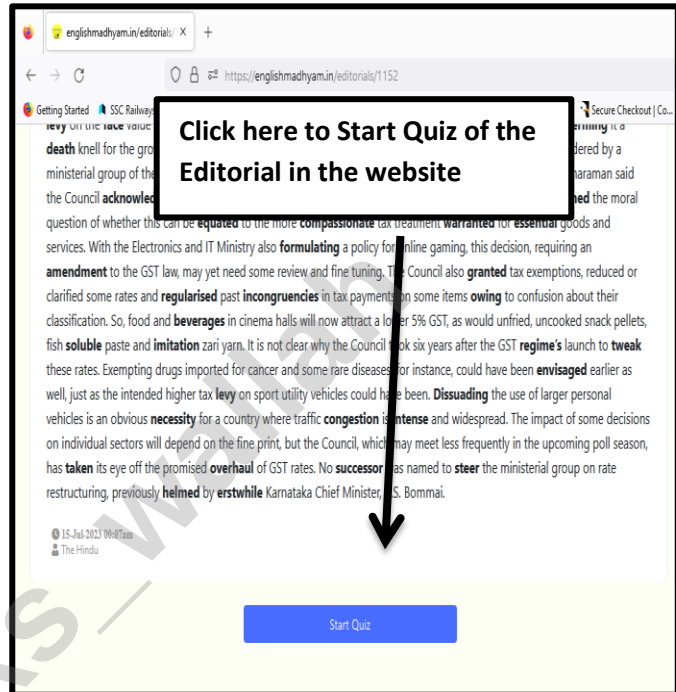
Summary of the Editorial

1. The UN Environment Programme (UNEP) has attempted six times since 2022 to establish a global treaty on plastic pollution.
2. The latest talks collapsed again due to sharp disagreements among major country blocs.
3. A key point of contention is whether eliminating plastic pollution requires reducing plastic production itself.
4. All nations acknowledge that polythene bags, once valued for their affordability and convenience, have now become a major civic problem.
5. India produces about **3.4 million tonnes of plastic waste annually**, but recycles only around 30%.
6. Between 2016-17 and 2019-20, India's plastic consumption grew rapidly, at a **CAGR of 9.7%**, rising from 14 MT to over 20 MT.
7. India has banned around 20 single-use plastic items, such as cups, straws, and spoons.
8. This ban has encouraged limited behavioural changes, with some shift to paper and cloth bags.
9. However, it has not significantly improved waste management or recycling efficiency.
10. Globally, over **430 MT of plastic** is produced annually, two-thirds of which are short-lived and quickly become waste.
11. About **46% of plastic waste** ends up in landfills, while **22% is mismanaged**, becoming litter.
12. Plastic, derived from fossil fuels, generated **1.8 billion MT of greenhouse gases in 2019** (3.4% of global emissions).
13. Critics argue that decades of efforts focusing only on recycling and waste collection have yielded limited progress.
14. Microplastics and plastic waste in oceans, food chains, and island shores highlight the urgency of reducing production at the source.
15. Without mutual trust and openness, future treaty negotiations risk becoming futile, as nations suspect hidden trade barriers behind calls to cut production.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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